SNAPSMACK OPERABILITY AUDIT — DING DONG BELL

OPAUDIT 013 — Fediverse replies were stored, approved, and never shown on any skin

Audit ID	2026-09-13-013
Report date	2026-09-13
First observed	2026-09-13, during a deliberate end-to-end comment test on allinthewrist.photoblogs.fyi (0.7.706D). Prompted by the snapsmack.ca home page claiming two-way comments and the co-author asking whether that claim had ever been checked.
Theme	"Works" was true of the database and false of the web page. Two comment tables, two one-way pipes, and nobody had ever looked at a public post as a reader.
Surfaces	Every skin's public comment thread (all 24 render the same component); the public comment form; inbound and outbound comment federation.
State	WATCHED WORKING inbound in 0.7.707D and outbound in 0.7.708D.
Watched live?	**Yes, both directions.** Two federated replies and one local comment were visible under the test post after 0.7.707D. On 2026-09-14, a comment typed on allinthewrist.photoblogs.fyi appeared under the same post on pixelfed.social after 0.7.708D.
Reporter	Sean (ran the test from three accounts, deployed, watched) + Claude (traced both tables, wrote both fixes).
Related	OPAUDIT 005 (inbound activity arrived, passed checks, then vanished — this is the next link in that chain: it arrived, passed, was stored, and vanished on the page); OPAUDIT 009 (Pixelfed likes).
Publication	Public. No exploitable detail.

1. SUMMARY

A reply sent from Pixelfed, Mastodon, or another SnapSmack site to a photograph on a SnapSmack blog was delivered, verified, matched to the right photograph, and approved — and then never appeared on the public page. Not on one skin: on all twenty-four. The owner could see it in the moderation screen, which is why it looked fine from the inside. Separately, a comment typed on the blog's own form never left the blog. Both halves of "comments federate" were broken in the same way: two tables, and each pipe only knew about one of them.

2. WHAT A HUMAN SAW

Sean replied to a post on allinthewrist.photoblogs.fyi from two places: the fediverse page on unzucked.ca (a SnapSmack site that follows it), and pixelfed.social. Both replies showed as sent on the sending side. Two likes arrived and were counted correctly (the heart showed 2). Neither reply appeared under the post. He then typed a comment directly into the post's own form; it appeared on the page (after a cache refresh) but never reached the fediverse.

3. ROOT CAUSE

SnapSmack has two comment tables. `snap_comments` is the classic table: the fediverse inbox writes inbound replies there (keyed to the image), and the moderation screen and the outbound federation code (`sv_federate_comment`) read from it. `snap_community_comments` is the community engine's table: the public form on every skin writes there, and the comment thread every skin renders (`core/community-component.php`) reads *only* from there.

So: inbound replies landed in a table the page never read. Local comments landed in a table the fediverse never read. Neither was a delivery failure, a signature failure, or a moderation hold. The plumbing on each side was correct and complete; the two sides had simply never been joined. This is the same shape as OPAUDIT 012 — an assumed invariant ("a comment is a comment") that nothing ever implemented.

4. EVIDENCE AT DIAGNOSIS

On the site's database (`allinthe`), the inbox receipt log showed both replies received and routed:

```
2026-09-13 15:17:48  Create  pixelfed.social/users/mccormickphoto  received — reply routed to image 37
2026-09-13 15:17:32  Like    pixelfed.social/users/mccormickphoto  resolved post:35 — recorded
2026-09-13 15:15:02  Like    unzucked.ca/ap/actor                  resolved post:35 — recorded
2026-09-13 15:15:01  Create  unzucked.ca/ap/actor                  received — reply routed to image 37
```

Both rows existed in `snap_comments` with `img_id = 37` , `is_approved = 1` , `is_spam = 0` , `ap_source = 'fediverse'` . Image 37 belongs to post 35 — the post the likes resolved to. The setting `fedi_auto_approve_replies` was unset (defaults to on). The typed comment existed in `snap_community_comments` with `post_id = 37` , `status = 'visible'` . A fetch of the post's rendered fragment contained the local comment and neither federated one. A search of every skin's layout found zero skins rendering `snap_comments` and all 24 including the community component.

5. WHAT WE DID

Inbound (0.7.707D "Loud and Clear"): the community component now also reads approved, non-spam `snap_comments` rows with `ap_source = 'fediverse'` for the photograph (or every photograph in the post, in post-keyed mode), merges them into the thread in date order, read-only, with a small "fediverse" tag and the commenter's handle linked to their profile. No migration; the existing rows simply become visible.

Outbound (0.7.708D "Both Ways"): every comment posted through the public form is now also written to `snap_comments` as an approved local row and handed to the same outbound pipe the moderation screen's owner-replies already used — threaded under the photograph's Note so it arrives as a reply on Pixelfed and Mastodon. The mirror row is marked local, so the thread never shows it twice.

A regression test (`tests/fediverse-replies-render-regression.php`) guards both joins. Known gap, stated in the changelog: hiding or deleting a community comment does not yet send a Delete to the fediverse.

6. VERIFIED LIVE — AND WHAT REMAINS

707D was packaged and deployed to allinthewrist.photoblogs.fyi the same afternoon. Opening the post showed all three comments in order: the unzucked reply, the pixelfed.social reply (both tagged FEDIVERSE), and the typed local comment — without re-sending anything. That is the inbound half, watched.

Resolution update, 2026-09-14: the outbound half was subsequently watched. A comment typed on allinthewrist.photoblogs.fyi appeared under the same post on pixelfed.social, attributed to the blog with the original time preserved. Both directions are therefore watched working; the separate ledger entry records that live result.

7. EYEBALL NEXT

Whether the moderation screen should show community-form comments alongside classic ones, now that they are mirrored (today they appear under different tabs). Whether hiding a community comment should retract the federated copy. And the older question this reopens: 1,904 comments on foreverphotograph.ing are still keyed to images rather than posts — the same two-shapes problem, on a larger archive.

8. THE DOCTRINE THIS INCIDENT CREATED

> *A feature is not working until someone has seen it on the public page the way a reader sees it. "It's in the database" and "the admin screen shows it" are not that. Every link in a chain can be individually correct and the chain still deliver nothing; the only test that counts is the one that starts where a stranger starts.*